



VertiGO!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 707 February 2008 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

R.I.P. Sir Edmund Hillary

Whaia te iti kahurangi, kei te tuohu koe, me te maunga teitei



Sir Edmund Hillary returning from the South Pole, 1957 "Official US Navy Photo" (courtesy of Pete de Joux in Antarctica)

The Wellington section joins the rest of New Zealand in saying farewell to Sir Edmund Hillary this week. As a Kiwi kid, I grew up with Sir Ed as my hero, but personally it wasn't until I trekked in Nepal, I really came to appreciate what a legend he was. Whenever the people of the Solu Khumbu found out I was from NZ, be they Sherpa or Rai, they would take me by the hand and lead me to show me this bridge, this hospital, this school that "their father Ed" had built for them. It made my heart swell with love for the man and pride to be a Kiwi. Thanks to all of you who emailed me your thoughts for inclusion in this newsletter (Rachael Schmidt – Editor)

From Pete de Joux giving the eulogy at Scott Base:

"If you ask most New Zealanders who they regard as heroes, they will usually name people whom they admire for their sporting achievements.

When Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay reached the summit of Mt Everest on May 29, 1953 it was really just a sporting achievement. It was a source of international pride for New Zealand and the rest of the British Commonwealth because it occurred at the same time as the coronation of the Queen. It was a significant act of exploration. As a mountaineer, I have some idea of how hard a task it was. But really it was just a couple of mountaineers achieving their sporting goal.

But I think Sir Ed is admired and respected more for what he achieved after he became famous, and how he behaved in the 55 years following that. He seemed to be embarrassed by his fame, but he used it to raise funds to build schools and hospitals in Nepal. He didn't allow his celebrity status to change the person he was, although his life would be very different from that day onwards.

When he learned that he was to be given a knighthood he said, "I could see myself walking down Broadway, Papakura in my tattered overalls and the seat out of my pants. And I thought that's gone forever. I'll have to buy a new pair of overalls now."

I only met Sir Ed on two occasions, but one of them was at his base. Although it is named after Robert Falcon Scott, it is Sir Ed who built it, and Sir Ed's attitudes that still exist there today. I remember November 26 2004 because it was my birthday. I had to give a tour of the science equipment at Scott Base to Sir Ed, and Phil Goff (our Minister for Foreign Affairs). I was quite nervous because of Sir Ed's status as an important visitor. But he immediately put me at ease and chatted about his friend and fellow member of the TransAntarctic Expedition, Trevor Hatherton, whom the lab is named after.

That night we had fish and chips for dinner. I remember this because the chefs put up a poster with a picture of Sir Ed holding a sign saying SIR ED'S FISH & CHIP SHOP.

This is an example of how Sir Ed participated in all the normal things that happened around the base. I know he loved being here, and one of the things he enjoyed was just sitting around in the bar or dining room chatting to the base staff. One day I sat with him and watched a televised rugby match in the bar at Scott Base. That's when I realised that Sir Ed the icon was also an ordinary New Zealander who loved being around other ordinary people.

The world has changed since 1953. But the values of humility, humour, and determination exhibited by Sir Edmund Hillary are just as relevant today as they have ever been.

The man has gone, but his memory will live on at Scott Base forever."

From Brian Wilkins on the 1954 Barun expedition:

"I think the time has arrived when we should venture from New Zealand to the overseas mountains". Dan Bryant, our Club President, our only Himalayan climber up to that time, made that clarion call at the 60th anniversary of the NZAC at the Hermitage in 1951. I was there listening to him, and two years later, along with three climbing friends, the Dunedin hopefuls on the short list for selection for the 1954 expedition, we were meeting Ed: and so, for Colin Todd and me, to Nepal.

The world tour, the razzle dazzle; how much had it taken out of Ed? A day or two into the hills he raced Charles Evans down a long slope to the Tamur and came second; not a fair contest though: Evans had kept well out of the limelight during those frenetic months after Everest.

Moving up to a 14,000ft pass to the Barun, Ed is cutting steps; I daresay the first he has cut since coming off Everest. The goal on these firm steep ridges of spring snow is nothing less than rescuing our expedition from disaster. Earlier we split into four parties, two plunging into rough Arun tributaries, while Jim McFarlane and Mike Ball are surveying above the Barun. Just the two of us are left to get the main body of expedition supplies across the pass.

Those parties have seriously depleted our forces, taking, all told, twenty six sherpas and bearers. Poor weather makes progress painfully slow. The number of loads littering the miserable hillside is four times our total complement of sherpas and bearers. Should the weather worsen, the latter group who sleep without tents, in the cold and wet among rocks and scrub, will be in real danger.

Ed's bucket steps have made the bearers more confident. I'm standing below the motley line that is passing across the slope above me, and I'm there to field anyone who slips. I think I can look after myself unroped, but if anyone comes my way I hope like hell that they've lost their load before they get to me; I can't stop both. None slipped; maybe they didn't trust me.

Space allows me to touch on only a few episodes from what, in 1954, was a vigorous and varied mountaineering achievement, a massive undertaking on the part of all concerned, and on a scale unprecedented for our Club.

Even before his accident and collapse Ed had not been well: my diary at Base Camp recorded his coughing, a bout of shivering, and his poor eating. Nevertheless he got plenty of satisfaction from what we achieved in those weeks in which he was fully active. From a peak 20,244ft, his first Himalayan climb after Everest, and the first such climb for McFarlane and me, we discovered that there was a feasible route to Makalu on that side. The route, behind a subsidiary range, can't be seen from Everest, and the Californians, who rejected it, had not gone high enough to see down into the crucial part of the Chago.

Poor visibility had prevented the Shipton party, including Ed, which came through the Barun a few years earlier, from making sense of the topography. It was therefore gratifying for him, during the next few days, to go with us into the Upper Barun sorting it all out, for the first time, while we planned the new routes. Unfortunately he didn't get back, and, following a serious encounter between Jim McFarlane and me and Ed, on one hand, and a crevasse on the other, he was destined to spend, as was Jim, time recuperating in Base. However Mike Ball, our doctor, who came briefly into the area to attend to Jim, came back with me later, as did Norman Hardie who had not been there previously, to make the first ascents of Pethangtse and other peaks in that wonderful place.

My fondest memory of my time in the mountains with Ed? Without doubt our long glissade, the three point standing slide, steering with the ice axe point grooving the snow behind, the two of us abandoning all ties to the others, shouting at the fun of it, careering down the faces and snow-filled gullies through the forest into the Barun, our reward for all the tough work on the pass. I think now of Hillary that day, the freedom he must have felt after eight months in the public glare, the naked mountaineer back among the places he loved."

And from Ken Stokes (summing it up):

"I was at the International Year of the mountains Conference and there were plenty of excellent speakers and wonderful slideshows. Then Sir Ed showed his own original 1953 black and white Everest trip slides himself, and spoke to them. It was like being at Club night and he was reporting on his last Christmas trip, it brought tears to my eyes.

A laconic humble man who was himself."

nzac national bouldering series 2008



www.nbr.org.nz



WAITOMO 16 February // BARING HEAD 23 February // JARDINES 8 March // SPITTLE HILL 15 March

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Crank, Crimp and Slap your way to the top of the 2008 National Bouldering Series at this year's Baring Head Rock Hop

Registration from 9.00am

Competitors briefing at 9.45am

Competition starts at 10.00am sharp!



The NBS is coiled and ready to dyno into the year. All the features of previous years; cool prizes, Chalky Digits limited edition T-shirts (available at the events), the NBS website and of course more problems than a Survivor episode.

Categories will be Expert, Junior and Recreational with male and female divisions in each.

Further information at www.nbs.org.nz or contact Chris North at (03) 3777595 or email at chris@alpineclub.org.nz.

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea and coffee afterwards. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up.



Section Night 4 February 2008

The first section night for 2008 will be held at Fergs. Admission will be free to Club members and there will also be a BBQ. We will need some help on the BBQ (free sausages) so please contact Blair on bh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz if you are keen to help out.



Section Trip News

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories. Thanks for all your stories this month. I have saved some back for next month, due to the tribute to Sir Edmund. But please keep them coming, and if you don't see your story here this month, watch for the March issue!



Climax!

Paul Grimwood, Alison Stevenson, David Jewell and Sharron Came made a successful ascent of Climax on the Olivine Ice Plateau on 28th December 2007. The route taken was in via the Beans Burn, over Fohn Saddle to the Olivine Ledge, down to the Olivine-Forgotton confluence, and then up the Forgotton River. Up and down from the plateau via Forgotton Col. Out over 4 Brothers Pass to the Diorite, down to the Pyke, through the Black Swamp, and a 6 km wade along the shore of Lake Alabaster. And then after 11 days of no real track, a crowded motorway of the Hollyford track and the Routeburn (via Deadmans Track) back to Glenorchy. Total trip

time 13 days with 1 bad weather day on the plateau, and 1 very short 2 hour day due to a very full Forgotton River.

Visceral and sensorial, a trip to the Olivine Ice Plateau cannot be truly described in words alone although a fair stab might be beef curry, beef curry, chicken curry, chicken curry, beef curry, beef curry, chicken curry, chicken curry, beef curry, beef curry, chicken curry, chicken curry (insert protein bar, 6 meal mates after every comma). But really the steady and continuous assault of body and mind over thirteen days has to be lived and experienced. Suffice to say we got a little beaten up by bush, buried by a blizzard, threatened by thunder crashing around the tent, and were wet, cold, hot, parched, tired and elated in some sort of repetitive 2 to 3 day cycle. Summitting climax the name seems fitting - after 7 days of walking and waiting peaks seem all that much sweeter. At no one point was the trip difficult or technical, but all added up to be quite a package. When we finished the trip we ate and ate and ate and swore never to touch another protein bar. Overall a great trip – HIGHLY RECOMMENDED, two thumbs up....



Wellington section new gear purchase

The Section has agreed to purchase up to three MT410G emergency locator beacons for use on courses and club trips and has applied to the Lion Foundation for funding for these. The beacon operates on the new 406MHz frequency that will replace the currently used 121.5/243 MHz frequency in February 2009. They also feature GPS integration for improved accuracy.

We will let you all know when these are available.



Wellington 2008 financial year and AGM

Last year the Club voted at its AGM to change its financial year from March – February to July – June. This has been implemented and consequently the Wellington Section has agreed to follow and make the same changes. This means that this years AGM will take place in August or September to enable sufficient time to present documents for the National AGM that is scheduled for October or November. We will firm up dates nearer the time.

If anyone has questions or concerns about this they should feel free to direct them to the committee through any of the elected officers.

Garth London (Chairperson)



FROM NATIONAL OFFICE – LIFE INSURANCE COVER WITHOUT MOUNTAINEERING EXEMPTIONS (AUSTRALIAN MEMBERS)

The NZ Alpine Club is delighted to announce that we have been able to successfully negotiate with ING Financial Planning to provide life insurance *without a mountaineering exclusion* to club members in Australia. Please check the National website for details.

NATIONAL OFFICE REQUEST - Old Annual Reports

As part of our ongoing sorting, it has come to light that our Hocken Archive Collection and National Reference Library are missing copies of our Annual Reports as follows:

Archive: Pre 1963, 64,65,66,68,69,78,79,83,87,89,93

Library: Pre 1998 (except 1981)

Please have a look to see if you have any old copies stashed away that you may be able to help us out with. They can be sent to Margaret at NZAC, PO Box456,Christchurch Mail Centre 8140

Thank you



WATCH OUT FOR WETAS!

Climbers to be on weta-watch at Mount Somers

The Department of Conservation and Lincoln University are carrying out research over the summer on the Mt Somers bluff weta (*Deinacrida elegans*) and seek any information on the whereabouts of this giant weta. The weta are usually found in crevices on cliffs and are recognised by their large body size (4–6 cm), olive coloured abdomen, orange and charcoal legs and white knees. They can also make a ‘grating’ distress call.

The research team is primarily interested in the location of the bluff weta within the Mt Somers area to determine its range and what makes this species so rare. Small isolated populations of this weta are known to exist in other South Island areas, so it is important to get a better picture of the extent of the Mt Somers population. The more that is understood about this weta’s

ecology including preferred habitat, diet, behaviours and threats including predation, the easier it will be to manage its future survival.

The impacts of introduced predators such as rats and stoats will be assessed through trapping and dietary analysis, and the use of tracking tunnels to map weta movements will help researchers to better understand the behaviour of this amazing weta species.

Two areas are being surveyed at Mt Somers, these are the Woolshed Creek site, and the Pinnacles site. The Pinnacles area is a popular climbing location and it is here that the research team hope to work with climbers to record sightings of the weta. Each hut has an information sheet to record weta sightings and their locations. Or alternatively you can direct any information or enquiries to Mike Bowie at Lincoln University:

e-mail: bowie@lincoln.ac.nz or phone (03) 325 2811 ext. 8388, or Warren Chinn at the Department of Conservation, e-mail: wchinn@doc.govt.nz or phone (03) 3713788 ext. 5488. The research team greatly appreciate the interest and support from the climbing community.

Cheers,
Mark

Mark Watson Editor
The Climber magazine / NZ Alpine Journal

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FOR SALE

For sale: Red Chilli **Spirit Rock Shoes** size 40. Worn half a dozen times but bought a size too large. \$140 includes postage from Wanaka (RRP \$179).

Contact Jo 03 443 6272, or email jo@spiderwebdesign.co.nz

CHECK OUT www.iclimb.co.nz for these tents and other great gear

Mont Bell Mighty Dome 2 Tent

A 2-person mountaineering tent weighing less than 1.5kg.

That's worth repeating: 1.5kg! The Mighty Dome is a specialist single-skin mountaineering tent (so is unlikely to suit the trampers out there) and you'll need to read the description below to determine if it's for you.

What is a single-skin tent? Probably every tent you have used is "double-walled" - having an inner tent and a fly over the top. The fly is not breathable but air circulates from underneath.

To save weight a tent can be made with only one wall (no fly) as long as that wall is waterproof. It will also need to be breathable and a large air vent is critical because generally condensation is a problem. These are single-skin tents.

Mont Bell Mighty Dome tents are made of Breeze Drytec, the world's most breathable highly waterproof material with Ballistic nylon (wicked strength for weight ratio). The poles are DAC Featherlite (important if you don't want a broken pole to shread your tent).

Specs are:

Unpackaged weight: 1.48kg

Packaged weight: 1.77kg

Optional vestibule weight: 290g

Breeze Drytec breathability: 15,000 g/m².24hrs (nearest competitor is 13,500 g/m².24hrs)

Wall waterproofness: 25,000mm hydrostatic head

Floor waterproofness: 2,000mm hydrostatic head



Mighty Dome 2 NZ\$650

optional vestibule NZ\$100



AND HERE ARE THE CLUB TRIPS

Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, send an email to trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz). Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going.

[Rockclimbing on Mt Taranaki](#)

[8 February, 2008 to 10 February, 2008.] Leader: James Wright

Level: Must be equipped for trad climbing

Climber on Pills & Thrills, Eiger Wall, Mt Taranaki

Long weekend at Mt Taranaki based at Tahurangi Lodge on the Northern Slopes. Multiple rock routes on various pillars and outcrops including Warwick's Castle and the Eiger wall.

Contact James Wright at james.wright@xtra.co.nz or call at (04) 232-7748

[Copland Valley - Easter 2008](#)

[21 March, 2008 to 30 March, 2008.] Easter Trip – led by "The Master".... Don French

Lyttle Peak from the Ruere approach, Copland Valley

There are plenty of mountaineering objectives off the Copland Valley. Easter is early this year. Hope to have a fairly large group heading up the easy access from the westcoast. Numerous objectives prevail.

[Mt Murchison - ANZAC Weekend April 2008](#)

[24 April, 2008 to 28 April, 2008.] Leader = Don French

Murchison from a distant Mt Rolleston

Highest peak in Arthurs Pass NP at 2408m. Route in will be up the Waimakariri River via Carrington Hut, then the White River to arrive at Barkers Hut at the base of the White Glacier. Ideal for those who have recently completed the AIC.

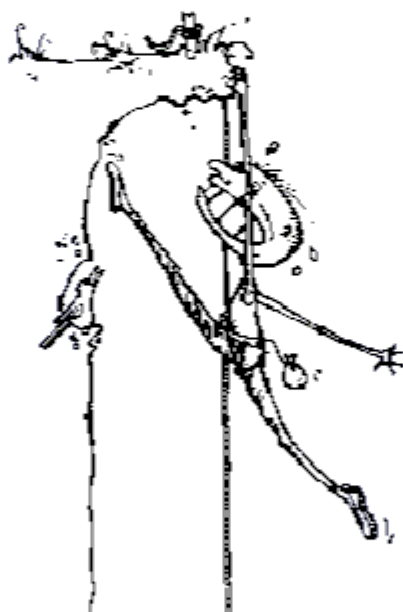
Contact Don at don.f@xtra.co.nz



Wellington Section Directory: 2008 contact list

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Patron			
Chairperson	Garth London	CHAIRPERSON <i>or</i> GL	(04) 479 2984
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Secretary	Rachel Depree	SECRETARY <i>or</i> RD	N/A
Treasurer	Karen Domaneschi	TREASURER <i>or</i> KD	N/A
National Representative	Jennifer Brown and James Wright	JB2 <i>or</i> JW	N/A
	Garth London and Judy Reid	GL <i>or</i> JR	(04) 479 2984 (Garth)
Instruction: AIC	Rachael Schmidt	RS <i>or</i> AIC	N/A
Instruction: RIC	Blair Hiscoke	SPRINGROCK	N/A
National Instruction Rep	Rachael Schmidt	RS	N/A
Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	KF	N/A
Trips	Kevin Patterson	TRIPS <i>or</i> KP	N/A
	Gwen Rashbrooke	TRIPS <i>or</i> GR	N/A
Library	Derek Richardson	LIBRARY	N/A
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	N/A
Committee Members	Hayden Cox	HC	N/A
	Paul Grimwood	PG	N/A
	Pete de Joux	PD	N/A
	Blair Hiscoke	BH	N/A
	Louise Thornley	LT	N/A
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* Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



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